

Black-tailed jackrabbit

Lepus californicus

Despite their name jackrabbits are in fact hares, not rabbits, with an above-ground lifestyle and a preference for outrunning predators, rather than diving into a burrow. A muscular, flexible body and long, powerful hind legs and feet act as a spring, giving the jackrabbit great speed and acceleration from a standing start.

Black-tailed jackrabbits are widespread in semiarid regions with sagebrush and creosote bush, and other open shrubland. They avoid searing heat by being active mostly at night. Unusually for hares, they occasionally burrow to escape excessive heat.

Precocious young

Females give birth to three to five fully furred, open-eyed young, called leverets, which are active soon after birth. Females can breed when under a year old, but the rate of predation is high—animals from pumas and coyotes to hawks and rattlesnakes eat jackrabbits. In favorable conditions, their numbers increase rapidly, but they fall again as food becomes scarce.



black patch on upper part of tail

▷ DUAL-PURPOSE EARS

Not only do jackrabbits have excellent hearing, but the ears also act as radiators in a breeze, cooling the blood.

↔ 19–25 in (47–63 cm)

⚖ 3–8 lb (1.5–3.5 kg)

⊗ Common

🌿 Grass, herbs, twigs

🏠



W., C., and
S. North America

large ears
laced with
fine blood
vessels

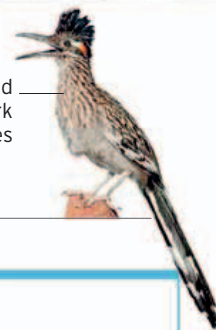
Greater roadrunner

Geococcyx californianus

Roadrunners are predominantly ground-dwelling birds that belong to the cuckoo family. They have long, strong, bare legs, with two toes facing forward and two backward—a feature not seemingly ideal for fast running. Roadrunners favor semidesert regions with open spaces as well as dry, bushy cover, but have spread into moister, greener habitats with scattered trees. They

are weak fliers but can get up onto treetops, wires, or roadside poles. Roadrunners eat lizards and mice, as well as small snakes and birds, snapping them up in their beak. This moisture-rich diet is an advantage when drinking water is scarce. They also conserve moisture by excreting excess salt from a gland near the eye, rather than wasting water in expelling it via the kidneys.

lighter throat and
chest with dark
stripes



↔ 22 in (56 cm)

⚖ 12 oz (340 g)

⊗ Common

🌿 Lizards, snakes, mice, birds

🏠



S. North
America

◁ DESERT RUN

The roadrunner is well adapted to life in the fast lane. It walks and runs through the desert, trying to flush out prey.

